

methods, that you want from the profuse list. And save your changes, of course.

Now, for some more configuration to ease up your experience. From the SCIM application's side panel, select **IMEngine**→**Generic Table** (see Figure 3). The main window here should show you three tabs in a stack. Here, in the 'Generic tab', you'll see five options that you can toggle to have SCIM complete your words as you type, and display key combinations for your words. This feature is not available for all the languages you installed, and didn't work in my SCIM set-up, although was shown as installed in **IMEngine**→**Generic Table**→**Table Management** tab. Huh!

You can also configure keyboard shortcuts in this window. A tip: if you must use them, do change the defaults that involve the **Ctrl+Shift** key combination—it conflicts with the paragraph selection shortcut of OpenOffice.org.

Finally, when you use SCIM, it'll display the SCIM Toolbar. This bar floats in the bottom right corner of your desktop, displaying the active layout. You can choose to turn this off if you like—**Panel**→**GTK**→**ToolBar**→**Show:Never** option.

We're now done configuring. Take a look at the tray of the panel on the top edge of your desktop. You'll see a keyboard icon there. That's the SCIM switcher. Click once on it to see the list of language layouts you chose earlier. Choose your language from the list. And you're ready to begin typing in your word processor or text editor.

The layouts

When you enable Indian language support in SCIM, you currently get eight Indian languages—Kannada, Telugu, Malayalam, Bengali, Gujarati, Hindi, Punjabi and Tamil. For the last five languages, you also have phonetic layouts (Hindi also includes Marathi). The phonetic layout is best for most users, as explained last month, while for very long sessions you would prefer the more ergonomic non-phonetic layouts. In Hindi, the non-phonetic users can choose between the Inscript and Remington layouts. These layouts are also available in KDE, by the way, so there's nothing to choose between the two desktops here.

In GNOME's SCIM, though, the Devanagari phonetic layout is—I hate to admit—better in at least some languages than KDE's Bolnagri, because it includes the 'Lla' (press **Shift+L**), and 'dnyā' (**Shift+6**) alphabets as used in some Devanagari scripts such as Marathi. A difference of style from KDE's Bolnagri is that, in the SCIM input here, the key F is used to join two alphabets together. So, for example, the name Partha, which includes the r-th sound, is produced thus: p+a+r+t+**F**[shift+T]. Easy enough!

What's more, there is yet another phonetic layout under development, primarily on the Ubuntu-India forum. I tried finding the source and installing it, but couldn't. It is said to mimic the layouts used by Baraha (the very competent and free-for-use, but sadly closed-source, Windows word processor). See if you can locate the source. You'll have to download and compile it in your terminal and configure it



Figure 1: SCIM main screen



Figure 2: A list of input methods

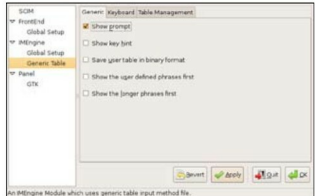


Figure 3: Some useful settings

through a short and easy, though manual, process.

Sign-off

GNOME's undoubtedly superlative accessibility features are almost matched by its increasing competence in Indian language support through SCIM. Time was when you either loved or hated GNOME—but it'll soon be pretty difficult to do the latter. **END** 

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